

Local Policies vs. Group Policies in Windows

In Windows operating systems, **Local Policies** and **Group Policies** are used to manage and enforce security and configuration settings. Here's a detailed comparison and explanation of both:

❏ 1. Local Policies

Local Policies are a subset of Group Policies but are applied only to the **local machine**.

❏ Where to Find It:

- Run ❏ `secpol.msc` (opens Local Security Policy)
- Or: Control Panel ❏ Administrative Tools ❏ Local Security Policy

❏ Components of Local Policies:

- 1.

Audit Policy – Determines what events are logged (e.g., logon, object access, etc.)

2.

User Rights Assignment – Defines what users can do (e.g., log on locally, shut down the system).

3.

Security Options – Miscellaneous security settings (e.g., UAC, admin approval mode, etc.)

☒ Use Cases:

- Standalone systems
- Testing environments
- Workgroup computers not part of a domain

☒ 2. Group Policies (GPOs)

Group Policies are configurations applied at the **domain level** using **Active Directory (AD)**. They allow centralized management of multiple machines.

☒ Where to Configure:

- Use the **Group Policy Management Console (GPMC)** ☒ gpmmc.msc
- GPOs can be linked to:
 - Sites
 - Domains
 - Organizational Units (OUs)

☒ Key Sections:

- **Computer Configuration** – Applies to computers regardless of the user.
- **User Configuration** – Applies to users regardless of the computer.

Each section has:

- Policies ☒ Software Settings, Windows Settings, Administrative Templates

☒ **Policy Inheritance Order:**

1.
Local
2.
Site
3.
Domain

4. OU

LSDOU – Later GPOs override earlier ones.

☒ Comparison Table

Feature	Local Policies	Group Policies
Scope	Local machine only	Multiple machines via AD
Tool	secpol.msc, gpedit.msc	gpmc.msc
Management	Decentralized	Centralized
Application	Immediately on the machine	Based on AD structure
User Types	Local users	Domain users and computers
Override	Can be overridden by GPOs	Can enforce organization-wide policies

☒ Example Scenario

Scenario	Use Local Policy	Use Group Policy
Set logon hours for a user on one PC	☒	☒
Enforce screensaver lock for all employees	☒	☒
Enable auditing of object access on a personal laptop	☒	☒
Disable USB ports company-wide	☒	☒

☒ Important Notes

- Local policies are overridden by GPOs if a computer is joined to a domain.

- Group Policies can be filtered using **security filtering** or **WMI filters**.
- Group Policies are updated every **90 minutes** by default (with random offset), or via gpupdate /force.